also, in his view, ‘a cowardly and deceitful sort of people, lying and deceit being so customary among them as not to be looked on as a sin’.

Ironically, Nieuhof was himself accused of illegal trading while in charge of the pearl fishery and was imprisoned for several months before returning home to Holland to write his memoirs. He later sailed for Madagascar and was never seen again.

The legitimacy of the Malabar caste order rested on two supposedly ancient texts: the *Kerala Mahatmayam* and the later *Keralolpathi* – dismissed by the British Collector of Malabar William Logan in the late-nineteenth century as ‘a farrago of legendary nonsense having for its definite aim the securing of the Brahmin caste of unbounded power and influence in the country’.[1] Logan’s remarks were aimed at one particular group of Brahmins known as the Nambudiris or Nambothris. They claimed Parashurama as their founding father and traced their ancestors back to sixty-five families drawn from the banks of the Narmada, Krishna and Kaveri rivers. After their arrival in the Malabar country they had established themselves in sixty-four exclusively Brahmin settlements, the most important being at Perumchallur, now better known as Taliparamba, in north Kerala.

The Nambudiris claimed to be the first Brahmins in the region, but it is more likely that they were preceded by others such as the Shivalli Brahmins, who claimed to have been brought south by the Alva kings in about the fourth century. The acutely caste-conscious Nambudiris looked down on the Shivallis and considered them as non-Brahmins, and the fact that they spoke Tulu, a language which Bishop Robert Caldwell described in his *Grammar* as ‘one of the most highly developed languages of the Dravidian family’, suggests that at the very least the first Shivalli immigrants had intermarried with the local Dravidian population.